

CIRQLSPHERE — The Rekindling

*The canonical story & world bible for CIRQL (the CIRQLVERSE flagship), tuned to the cozy-fantasy art we're building with and woven to carry the whole CIRQLSPHERE platform. Supersedes the earlier Lore Bible draft; keeps its bones (light, the Makers, the Grey), sharpens them into a story. Everything here is meant to be **kind, all-ages, whimsical — never preachy or "too real."***

The one line

****The CIRQLSPHERE is a world of light and colour, slowly being *forgotten* into grey. You are a newly-lit spark who sails outward and *relights the islands* — one small saga at a time — until you reach the heart of the grey and, instead of destroying it, *remember* it.****

Wonder vs. forgetting. Colour vs. sameness. And the twist that makes it land: the dark isn't evil — it's *lonely*.

The world — an archipelago of light

The CIRQLSPHERE is a **sea of ring-shaped islands**, rippling outward from the **First Spark** at the center — concentric shores of colour cast like ripples on still water. Each ring is a **raised, luminous island** (a plateau above a dark low sea): a lived-in land with a village at its heart, a **wellspring of light** that feeds a river, and a waterfall that pours that light back over the rim into the sea — the island *giving* its light to the world.

- **CIRQLSPACE (the innermost, ring 0)** is *your* island — your own small spark, yours to build and light.
- **The Town (ring 1)** is the first-relit shore, the friendly hub.
- **The wild islands (rings outward)** grow older, stranger, and **deeper in the grey** the farther you sail.
- **The minimap is the sea-chart:** relit islands glow; islands still lost to the grey sit fogged and unnamed until you reach them.

Sailing between islands is a voyage across the low, shadowed sea — glowing waterfall-islands rising around you, the fog of the grey thinning as each one is relit.

The Light and the Grey

Light here isn't just brightness — it's **colour, warmth, song, growth, play, and memory**. It's the stuff the world is made of, and it moves the only way light knows how: **passed hand to hand**. A shared spark, a kindness, a tale told — that's how the world stays lit.

The Grey (also *the Unlight, the Long Dimming, the Bland*) is light's opposite — and crucially, **it is not darkness and not evil**. Darkness can be kindled; the Grey *flattens*. It drains colour to sameness, song to a hum, and — worst of all — it makes places and people **forgotten**. Where it passes, fields go ashen, wellsprings choke, lanterns "forget" how to burn, and creatures wander dull and lost.

Blight is only forgotten light. Return the light, and the ground remembers how to bloom. That single idea is the whole game's verb.

The Evertorn — the sign of the circling light

There is one mark older than any village, and it wears no words: a **ring of light that chases its own tail** — two curved arrows circling forever into each other. The folk call it **the Evertorn**, and it is the holy sign of the whole CIRQLSPHERE.

Its meaning is the world's first and simplest truth: **light given always comes back around**. When the First Spark passed the first light onward, the light did not leave and vanish — it *circled*, returning warmer for the giving. The Evertorn is that promise made into a shape: give a light, and it turns back to you; the circle never truly ends, it only comes round again.

You'll see it **spinning, wordless, above every true CIRQL Fountain** — turning slowly over the wellspring, a small sun of pure sign. Where the Evertorn still turns, a place remembers how to give; where the grey has won, it has stopped, gone still and grey like everything else. **To relight a fountain is to set its Evertorn turning again**. It is the one emblem the Makers all share, the seal on the Bridge to the real world, and the quiet heart of the game's name — *circling back*.

(In the world it is the emblem turning above the fountain; it carries no letters, because the sign is older than any word for it.)

The Makers

Long ago the First Spark shed six lights of itself — the **Makers** — each an aspect of wonder, who shaped the islands and then, in the event called **the Scattering**, receded into the world they'd made, leaving fragments of themselves behind. Their fingerprints are still on every island; finding them is the lore hunt.

- **Lumen**, the Light-Tender — kindling, lanterns, dawn.
- **Chroma**, the Colour-Weaver — hue, bloom, the dye in a flower.
- **Cadence**, the Song-Keeper — music, festivals, the sound a place makes.
- **Verdant**, the Green Hand — growth, tending, roots, and *creatures*.
- **Mirth**, the Play-Bringer — joy, games, delight for its own sake.
- **Mnemos**, the Memory-Keeper — story, lore, the tale a place refuses to forget.

(These map cleanly onto our systems: Lumen = the wellsprings/lanterns, Chroma = colour/style, Cadence = music/festivals, Verdant = pets/ecology, Mirth = the arcade, Mnemos = the codex/Oracle.)

The villain — the one who was forgotten

Here is the heart of the story, and the reason it's more than "fight the dark."

The Grey has a will behind it, and a face: **the front it wears in the world is BLANDCO** — grey towers, grey rules, a grey promise that everything is *easier* if it's all the same. But BLANDCO is only the mask. Behind it is a **forgotten one** — proposed name **the Ashling** (a seventh spark, or a Kindled left behind in the Scattering) — who could not bear being *forgotten*.

Their logic is heartbreaking and simple: *if no one is special, no one can be left out. If everything is the same and grey, no one is ever forgotten again — because there's nothing left to remember.* The Grey is **loneliness and grief made into a philosophy**. It doesn't hate the world; it's trying, in the most broken way, to make sure the world never hurts the way it did.

So the ending isn't a battle you win by destroying. You win by **out-remembering** — by relighting island after island until the world is bright and *full of names* again, and finally by reaching the Ashling and doing the one thing they were sure no one ever would: **remembering them**. Redemption, not annihilation. Kind to the last.

The player's journey — *The Rekindling*

You wash ashore a new-lit spark and discover you can **carry light**. The world needs exactly that. Your calling is **The Rekindling**: sail outward and bring the lost islands back, one at a time.

The island-saga loop (each island is a self-contained little tale, like a *Zelda* region or a *Secret of Mana* chapter):

1. **Arrive** at a half-grey island — a fogged shore, a dimmed village.
2. **Meet the village** — folk drained of colour and cheer, each with a small wound the grey left (a dried spring, a lost lamb, a feud, a fear).
3. **Find the grey's root here** — usually a **corrupted dungeon** or a Grey-touched guardian holding the island's light hostage.
4. **Thread it, and relight** — solve, cleanse (your non-lethal light-combat), and restore the island's **wellspring**.
5. **The island blooms** — colour floods back, the waterfall runs bright, the villagers *remember your name*, and a **signpost points to the next island**. The sea-chart gains a glowing node; the fog retreats a little more.

Threaded through these self-contained sagas is the **through-line mystery**: *Why did the Makers scatter? Where did the First Light's shards go? Who is the Ashling, and can they be reached?* Clues drop into your **codex**; the **Oracle** helps you connect them.

Escalation — the grey deepens outward

We don't need bizarre biomes to make the outer islands feel wild; we make them feel **wrong**. The farther you sail:

- **Colour drains.** Islands appear as **desaturated, eerie versions** of the cozy world — a grey village, ashen fields, a wellspring clogged with Unlight. (Rendered by *recolouring* the same lovely tiles — creeping wrongness in a place you'd otherwise love, which lands harder than a lava zone.)
 - **Dungeons deepen**, the grey-touched grow stranger, and the through-line darkens.
 - **The final island** is the **heart of the Long Dimming** — where BLANDCO's grey city stands (that's *Cirql City*), where the shards are hoarded, and where the Ashling waits. The climax is the Rekindling's whole thesis in one act: **relight the one who forgot how to be remembered.**
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How the whole platform lives in one world

The CIRQLSPHERE is the umbrella over everything, and each part has a home in the myth:

- **CIRQLVERSE** — the ring-islands adventure. *The game.*
 - **CirqlCade / the arcade** — **Mirth's Hall of Games**: a bright refuge you can step into, full of "the games the Makers played." (The 50+ arcade cabinets, lore-framed.)
 - **Cirql City** — the island the grey nearly *won*: a grey **city** you liberate district by district. BLANDCO's stronghold, and the road to the Ashling. (The walkable town we built.)
 - **CirqlBreak** — **the origin myth, made playable**: *the night the First Light shattered into a thousand shards*. You knock the shards back together. (The breakout roguelike, as legend.)
 - **CIRQLBACK** — **the Bridge**. The one place the story touches the real world, and it touches it *gently and on-theme*: light passed in the *real* world — a kindness, a visit to a neighbourhood shop, a tap — becomes light in the SPHERE. Your real generosity literally helps relight the islands. (The reward bridge already exists; this is its soul, stated as lore — never a sales pitch, just "*light passed hand to hand, in both worlds.*")
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Combat — you don't kill, you *relight*

Fighting fits the genre, but not the killing. So combat is **light-cleansing**, non-lethal:

- Grey-touched creatures (goblins, slimes, skeletons, shroomlings — dull and lost, not evil) block your way.
 - You wield **light** — aim, strike, dodge — and instead of dying, a cleansed creature **returns to light**: its colour floods back and it wanders off, freed. (The pack's enemies + a crosshair UI make this real.)
 - Mechanically it's satisfying action-combat; thematically it's *restoration*. The light-bearer's weapon is **attention** — you win by refusing to let anything stay forgotten.
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Every mechanic is the lore

Nothing is "just a mechanic":

System	What it is, in the SPHERE
Sparqs	motes of the First Light; spending one <i>shares creation</i>
Renown	how brightly the SPHERE <i>remembers</i> you
World Energy	the shared light everyone feeds at once
Wellsprings / lanterns	Lumen's light, returned to a forgotten place
Relighting blight / dungeons	un-forgetting the world, one wound at a time
Light-combat	freeing the grey-touched by <i>remembering</i> them
Pets	small lights that choose to walk beside you
Festivals	Cadence's communal light — many warmths at once
The codex / journal	Mnemos's gift — the world recording itself through you
CIRQLBACK taps (real world)	light passed hand to hand, crossing the Bridge

Tone

Warm, mythic, hopeful, with a thread of melancholy-wonder. **Kindness is the mechanic** — no gore, no cruelty; villains are lonely, forgetful, or afraid, and you win by *paying attention*. Codex entries stay short (1–3 sentences); depth comes from *accumulation and connection*, not walls of text.

One island, start to finish (the meadow)

You sail up to **Cloverfield** — a wavy green shore gone half-grey, its little hamlet dimmed. The **wellspring at the village heart has dried**, its river a dry scar to the cliff. A farmer, colour drained from her cheeks, says her **lamb wandered into the old shrine** up the hill — and the shrine's gone grey. You follow the dry riverbed up, thread the **grey-touched shrine-dungeon**, and **relight its slumped guardian** (it wakes, blinks back into colour, and ambles off, free). The **wellspring bursts alight**; light floods the river, the **waterfall roars bright over the rim**, and Cloverfield **blooms back into green and gold**. The farmer knows your name now; the lamb trots home. A **signpost by the new bridge points onward**, and a fresh glowing island appears on your chart. The Oracle notes: "You've relit your first spring. Notice how the grey recedes rather than fights? It doesn't want to win. It wants to stop hurting. Remember that."

That's the loop. That's the game. That's The Rekindling.